

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 17 & 18

CHAPTER 17: ERIN'S SECOND 3:00

The law firm of *Gunderson, Skiles & Bruner* occupied the top three floors of the Hancock Tower. It was a fortress of glass, steel, and billing hours. At 2:00 AM, it was a ghost town.

Erin Bruner sat in her corner office. The only light came from her desk lamp—a green banker's lamp that cast long, sickly shadows—and the city grid burning below.

She was working on her cross-examination of Father Moore.

Q: Father, did you tell Emily to stop eating?

A: I told her to fast and pray.

Q: And did you know fasting would kill her?

A: I knew the demon was feeding on her strength.

Erin rubbed her temples. The headache was back. A tight band of iron wrapped around her skull.

She reached for her water glass.

It was empty.

She sighed, pushing her chair back. The leather creaked.

She walked out into the hallway.

The corridor was silent. The plush carpet swallowed her footsteps.

She walked to the kitchenette. The refrigerator hummed. *Hummmm-click. Hummmm-click.*

She opened it. The light was harsh, blinding.

She grabbed a bottle of water.

As she closed the door, she saw her reflection in the stainless steel.

She looked... wrong.

Her face was distorted by the curve of the metal. Her eyes looked too big. Her mouth looked too wide.

And behind her...

In the reflection...

There was a shape.

Standing in the doorway of the kitchenette.

Erin spun around.

Empty.

Just the long, dark hallway.

"You need sleep, Bruner," she whispered. "You're cracking up."

She walked back to her office.

But the walk felt longer this time. The hallway seemed to stretch, like a camera dolly zoom.

She reached her door.

It was closed.

She had left it open.

She stared at the wood. Mahogany. Solid core.

Maybe the cleaning crew closed it.

She turned the handle.

Locked.

She frowned. She patted her pockets. Her keys were on her desk. Inside.

"Great," she muttered. "Just great."

She leaned closer to the door.

She heard a sound from inside.

Scritch. Scritch.

Like a pen scratching on paper.

"Hello?" she called out. "Is someone in there?"

Silence.

Then... *Whirrrrr.*

The sound of her Dictaphone rewinding.

Click.

Play.

Erin's own voice floated through the door, muffled by the wood.

"...Dr. Vogel... how did the voice know your name..."

Click.

Rewind. *Whirrrrr.*

Play.

"...know your name... name... name..."

Click.

Rewind.

Whirrrrrrrrr.

The rewind sound got louder. Higher pitched. Like a scream.

Erin backed away.

"Security!" she yelled. Her voice echoed in the empty hall.

The rewinding stopped.

Silence.

Then, a new sound.

Thump.

Something heavy hitting the floor.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

Footsteps.

Heavy, dragging footsteps. Walking toward the door.

Erin froze. She couldn't breathe. The air in the hallway turned ice cold. She could see her breath.

The doorknob turned.

Slowly.

Creak.

It rattled.

Then it stopped.

A voice spoke from the other side.

It wasn't on the Dictaphone. It was right against the wood.

"...Erin..."

It sounded like wet gravel.

"...we are ready for you..."

The lights in the hallway flickered. *Buzz-click. Buzz-click.*

They went out.

Total darkness.

Erin screamed.

She turned and ran.

She ran blindly down the hall, her hands outstretched. She hit the wall. *Thud.*

She scrambled along the wall, feeling for the elevators.

"Security! Help me!"

She reached the elevator bank. She slammed her hand against the call button.

It didn't light up.

Power outage.

She looked back down the hall.

At the far end... near her office...

A light appeared.

Not an electric light.

A dull, orange glow.

Like a fire.

Or eyes.

Two glowing orange orbs, floating in the dark.

They were moving toward her.

Bobbing.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

The dragging footsteps.

Erin scrambled for the stairwell door. She pushed the bar.

Locked.

"No," she whimpered. "No, no, no."

She turned back to the elevator.

The orange eyes were closer. She could smell it now.

Sulfur.

And burning meat.

"Do you think you can win?"* the voice whispered. It was coming from everywhere. From the ceiling. From the floor. "Do you think the Law can bind us?"*

Erin slid down the elevator doors, curling into a ball.

She covered her ears.

"It's not real. It's not real. It's not real."

"We are the only thing that is real,"* the voice laughed.

The heat hit her.

A wave of hot, stinking air.

She looked up.

The eyes were right in front of her.

And in the orange glow, she saw a face.

It wasn't a human face.

It was a mask of flayed skin. Muscle and bone.

It opened its mouth.

And screamed.

DING.

The elevator doors opened behind her.

Erin fell backward into the car.

The lights inside were bright. Normal.

She scrambled up, hitting the 'L' button.

The doors closed.

Just before they shut, she saw the hallway.

It was empty.

Dark. Silent.

No orange eyes. No smell of sulfur.

Just an empty office building at 3:00 AM.

Erin slumped against the wall of the elevator. She was shaking so hard her teeth chattered.

She looked at her watch.

3:01.

The second hand was moving.

Tick-tick.

She looked at her hand.

There was a bruise on her wrist.

A perfect handprint.

Purple and black.

Large fingers.

She touched it. It burned.

She wasn't crazy.

It had touched her.

It had marked her.

She closed her eyes as the elevator descended.

She knew what she had to do.

She had to put Moore on the stand.

Not to win the case.

But because he was the only one who knew how to fight the dark.

CHAPTER 18: WITNESS: THE PRIEST

The courtroom was packed. Standing room only.

The air was electric. You could feel the tension vibrating in the wood of the benches.

"The defense calls Father Richard Moore."

A murmur went through the crowd.

Moore stood up.

He smoothed his cassock.

He walked to the witness stand.

He didn't look at the jury. He didn't look at the judge.

He looked at Erin.

His eyes were clear. Calm.

He placed his hand on the Bible.

"I do," he said.

He sat down.

Erin walked to the podium.

She felt the bruise on her wrist throbbing under her suit jacket. It was a reminder. A brand.

"Father Moore," she began. "Why did you perform an exorcism on Emily Rose?"

"Because she was possessed," Moore said. His voice was quiet, raspy. "Because the medical treatment was killing her."

"Objection," Owen Thomas said, not looking up from his notes. "Medical conclusion from a non-expert."

"Sustained," Judge Brewster said. "The jury will disregard the second part of the answer."

Erin nodded. "Father, did you tell Emily to stop taking her medication?"

"I told her that the medication was silencing her soul. I told her that she had a choice."

"And what did she choose?"

"She chose to fight."

Erin walked closer.

"Father, the prosecution claims you were negligent. That you ignored the medical facts. That you let a girl die because of your... superstition."

Moore looked at Owen.

"Superstition is a word we use for things we are afraid to understand."

"Were you afraid, Father?"

"Yes."

"Of what?"

"Of failing her."

"And did you fail her?"

Moore paused. He looked at his hands.

"I failed to save her body," he whispered. "But I did not fail her soul."

Erin turned to the jury.

"Tell us about the night of October 31st. Halloween."

A hush fell over the room.

"It was storming," Moore said. "The barn was cold. We had Emily on the cot. We had restraints."

"Why restraints?"

"Because when the entities took control... she had the strength of ten men. She would have hurt herself. She would have hurt us."

"Entities? Plural?"

"Yes."

"How many?"

"Six."

Erin let the number hang there.

"And did you speak to them?"

"I commanded them to reveal themselves."

"And did they?"

"Yes."

Owen stood up. "Your Honor, I must object. We are now entering the realm of theology, not fact. We cannot cross-examine a demon."

"We are establishing the defendant's state of mind," Erin argued. "If he believed he was talking to demons, it explains his actions."

"I'll allow it," Brewster said. "But tread carefully, Ms. Bruner."

Erin looked at Moore.

"Tell us the names, Father."

Moore closed his eyes. He seemed to be in pain.

"They spoke in different voices," he said. "Different languages."

"What did they say?"

"One said... 'I am the one who dwelt within Cain'."

The jury shifted. Juror 11 (The Nurse) crossed herself.

"Another said... 'I am the one who dwelt within Nero'."

Moore's voice grew louder. Stronger.

"Another said... 'I once dwelt within Judas'."

The temperature in the courtroom seemed to drop. Or maybe it was just the collective shiver of the audience.

"And the others?"

"One was Legion. One was Belial."

"And the last one?"

Moore opened his eyes. He looked directly at Owen Thomas.

"The last one," Moore whispered, "did not speak a name. It spoke a title."

"What title?"

"I am Lucifer, the Devil in the Flesh."

The silence that followed was absolute.

It wasn't just quiet. It was a vacuum.

Then, a sound.

Crack.

A lightbulb in the ceiling fixture above the witness stand exploded.

Glass rained down.

People screamed.

Judge Brewster banged his gavel. "Order! Order!"

Erin didn't move. She looked at Moore.

He hadn't flinched.

He was looking at the empty air above the jury box.

He was smiling.

A sad, knowing smile.

"They are here," he whispered. "They are listening."

Erin looked at the jury.

They were terrified.

Not of Moore.

Of the room.

Of the shadows in the corners.

She had done it. She had broken the wall of rationality.

She had let the contagion in.

"No further questions," she whispered.

She sat down.

Her hand was shaking.

She put it under the table.

She touched the bruise on her wrist.

It was hot. Burning hot.

As if the hand that made it was still holding on.